

A Sabbatical in Film

42 weeks · 24 Aug 2026 – 4 Jul 2027 · 85 core films, approx. 127 with extensions

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How to use this

Each week has **two core films** and **one optional extension**. Two is the floor; take the extension in weeks when you have the time or the unit has its hooks in you. That lands you at 2–3 films a week as planned, without the schedule becoming a debt you owe.

Four weeks list three or four core films rather than two. In every case the extras are **short** — 14 to 32 minutes — and are marked as such. They're there because avant-garde and documentary work is where the formal vocabulary gets isolated most clearly, and skipping it entirely would leave a real hole. A 28-minute film is not a third film; it's an appendix to the one before it.

Films are grouped into **13 units of 3–4 weeks**. Within a unit, the films talk to each other — an influence, a rebuttal, a second attempt at the same problem. This is the whole design. A single Antonioni film is a slog; three Antonioni-adjacent films in a row and you start to see what he was actually doing, which is when it gets interesting.

Three rules that matter more than the list:

1. **One film per sitting, no phone.** These were built for uninterrupted attention and collapse without it.
2. **Write 3–4 sentences after each one** — before you read anything about it. What did the camera do? What surprised you? What annoyed you? You know better than most that unrecorded observation evaporates.
3. **Read the criticism *after*, never before.** One piece, ten minutes. Unit-level reading is listed below; the [Reading Companion](#) has linked essays for every individual film.

Where to find these: the Criterion Channel covers a large majority of this list and is the single best subscription for the project. MUBI, Kanopy (free with most university logins — check Berkeley's), and your library fill most of the rest.

Optional scaffolding: Bordwell & Thompson, *Film Art: An Introduction*. Read chapters 4–6 (mise-en-scène, cinematography, editing) during Unit 1. It's about 100 pages and it gives you vocabulary you'll use for the remaining 40 weeks. This is the closest thing to the class you never took.

If you fall behind: don't catch up. Drop the extensions, drop a week, rejoin at the next unit boundary. The units are self-contained on purpose.

Unit 1 • The Grammar

Weeks 1–3 • 24 Aug – 13 Sep 2026

Six films chosen because each one makes a formal technique impossible to miss. Watch these with Bordwell open. The goal isn't to love them — it's to leave with words for what you're seeing, so that everything after lands differently.

Week 1 • Aug 24–30

- *Citizen Kane* (1941, Welles) — deep focus, and a film that narrates itself in fragments. The whole vocabulary of “showy” filmmaking starts here.
- *Rear Window* (1954, Hitchcock) — the purest demonstration of how editing constructs meaning. Two shots, one implication, no dialogue.
- *Optional: North by Northwest* (1959, Hitchcock) — the crop-duster sequence is the standard textbook example of how editing builds tension out of nothing. Hitchcock appears in these academic syllabi more than any other director, and this is the film they teach.

Week 2 • Aug 31 – Sep 6

- *Do the Right Thing* (1989, Lee) — color, heat, and camera height as argument. Notice the Dutch angles arrive before the violence does.
- *Chungking Express* (1994, Wong Kar-wai) — step-printing, handheld, and the discovery that a film's texture can carry its emotion entirely.
- *Optional: Killer of Sheep* (1978, Burnett)

Week 3 • Sep 7–13

- *Rashomon* (1950, Kurosawa) — the same events, four times. Watch how the camera's behavior changes with each teller.
- *The 400 Blows* (1959, Truffaut) — the long take and the freeze frame; how withholding a cut creates unease.
- *Optional: Bicycle Thieves* is coming in Unit 4 — instead try *A Man Escaped* (1956, Bresson)

Read: Roger Ebert's *Great Movies* essay on *Citizen Kane*; Bordwell & Thompson chs. 4–6.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 2 • The Studio System

Weeks 4–7 · 14 Sep – 11 Oct 2026

Classical Hollywood at full operating efficiency. These are, without qualification, fun — which is the point. Genre is a set of constraints, and watching great directors work inside constraints is the fastest way to see directorial choice at all. Pay attention to how much these films accomplish in 95 minutes.

Week 4 · Sep 14–20 — Screwball

- *It Happened One Night* (1934, Capra)
- *His Girl Friday* (1940, Hawks) — the dialogue overlaps by design. Don't fight it.
- *Optional: The Lady Eve* (1941, Sturges)

Week 5 · Sep 21–27 — The Western

- *Red River* (1948, Hawks)
- *The Searchers* (1956, Ford) — the most influential and most morally uncomfortable American film of its decade. The doorway shots bookend it for a reason.
- *Optional: Stagecoach* (1939, Ford)

Week 6 · Sep 28 – Oct 4 — Noir

- *Double Indemnity* (1944, Wilder)
- *The Third Man* (1949, Reed) — noir style exported to bombed-out Vienna, with a zither.
- *Optional: Out of the Past* (1947, Tourneur)

Week 7 · Oct 5–11 — Hollywood on itself

- *Singin' in the Rain* (1952, Donen & Kelly)
- *Sunset Boulevard* (1950, Wilder) — the same subject, the sound-era transition, told as a horror film. Watch these back to back and the pairing does the work.
- *Optional: The Bad and the Beautiful* (1952, Minnelli)

Read: Manny Farber, “Underground Films” (1957) — his case for Hawks, Walsh, and Mann as unpretentious craftsmen, and against exactly the prestige-Ford register of *The Searchers*. Useful precisely because it argues with this week's assignments.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 3 · Silents, the Short Version

Weeks 8–10 · 12 Oct – 1 Nov 2026

You said silents are less appealing, so this unit is deliberately small and front-loaded with pleasure. Note the runtimes — **every film in this unit is under 95 minutes**, and four are under 70. Keaton first, because *Sherlock Jr.* is 45 minutes of the most inventive physical filmmaking ever committed,

and it will recalibrate your expectations before you meet Dreyer.

Weeks 9 and 10 carry an extra title each. Week 9 adds German Expressionism, which the plan otherwise skipped entirely and which every film-history course treats as foundational — and which Unit 2's noir week is directly descended from. Week 10 adds two very short avant-garde films for the same reason: they isolate what narrative films do invisibly.

Week 8 · Oct 12–18 — Keaton

- *Sherlock Jr.* (1924, Keaton) — 45 min. A projectionist walks into the movie he's showing. In 1924.
- *The General* (1926, Keaton) — 79 min.
- *Optional: City Lights* (1931, Chaplin) — 87 min

Week 9 · Oct 19–25 — Expressionism and the image at full power

- *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* (1920, Wiene) — 77 min. Painted shadows, tilted walls, a set that behaves like a state of mind. Watch it and Week 6's noir stops looking like an American invention.
- *Sunrise* (1927, Murnau) — 94 min. Murnau brings the Expressionist toolkit to Hollywood; the camera moves like nothing else would for thirty years.
- *The Passion of Joan of Arc* (1928, Dreyer) — 82 min. Almost entirely faces. It is not a comfortable film, but it is a short one.
- *Optional: Metropolis* (1927, Lang) or *Nosferatu* (1922, Murnau)

Week 10 · Oct 26 – Nov 1 — Montage and the avant-garde

- *Man with a Movie Camera* (1929, Vertov) — 68 min. A city symphony and a film about filmmaking; no plot, no intertitles, endlessly watchable.
- *Battleship Potemkin* (1925, Eisenstein) — 75 min. Read the Odessa Steps sequence as the argument for editing that everything after is answering.
- *Un Chien Andalou* (1929, Buñuel & Dalí) — **16 min.** Surrealism's demonstration that film can dispense with continuity entirely and still hold you.
- *Meshes of the Afternoon* (1943, Deren) — **14 min.** The most-taught avant-garde film there is; it appears in more of the academic syllabi than *His Girl Friday*. Watch it twice — it's fourteen minutes.
- *Optional: The Crowd* (1928, Vidor)

Four films, but the last two total half an hour. Real week runtime: about 2h 50m.

Read: David Bordwell's blog, "Sherlock Jr." posts; Eisenstein's short essay "A Dialectic Approach to Film Form" (skim — the theory is dense, the examples are clear).

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 4 · Italy: Rubble to Ennui

Weeks 11–13 · 2 – 22 Nov 2026

Postwar Italian cinema runs an arc in fifteen years from filming actual bombed streets with non-actors to filming rich people being bored in beautiful rooms. That arc is one of the most legible in film history, and each film comments on the last.

Week 11 · Nov 2–8

- *Rome, Open City* (1945, Rossellini) — shot in the months right after the Germans left Rome, partly on scrounged film stock, in a city that hadn't yet been repaired.
- *Bicycle Thieves* (1948, De Sica) — the neorealist thesis in its clearest form: no stars, real locations, a plot that could be a footnote.
- *Optional: Umberto D.* (1952, De Sica)

Week 12 · Nov 9–15

- *L'Avventura* (1960, Antonioni) — a woman disappears and the film loses interest in finding her. Booed at Cannes; then it wasn't.
- *Il Sorpasso* (1962, Risi) — the comedy that diagnoses exactly the same postwar emptiness, and is a delight. The pairing is the lesson.
- *Optional: L'Eclisse* (1962, Antonioni)

Week 13 · Nov 16–22

- *8½* (1963, Fellini) — a director who can't make his film, making it.
- *The Conformist* (1970, Bertolucci) — Storaro's cinematography is the reason half of New Hollywood looks the way it does. Watch it and then rewatch bits of *The Godfather* in Unit 8.
- *Optional: La Dolce Vita* (1960, Fellini) — 174 min

Read: Criterion's essays on *L'Avventura* and *8½*.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 5 · The French New Wave and What It Stole**Weeks 14–16 · 23 Nov – 13 Dec 2026**

The trick with the New Wave is that it's usually taught as a rupture. It's more useful as theft: a group of critics who loved American genre film and remade it with handheld cameras and no money. Each week here pairs a New Wave film with the thing it was stealing from or handing off to.

Week 14 · Nov 23–29

- *Bob le Flambeur* (1956, Melville) — the low-budget location-shot crime film that showed the younger critics it could be done.
- *Breathless* (1960, Godard) — then the jump cuts. Having seen Melville first, you'll see what's

new and what isn't.

- *Optional: The Killing* (1956, Kubrick)

Week 15 · Nov 30 – Dec 6

- *Cléo from 5 to 7* (1962, Varda) — near-real-time, and the best film of the movement by some distance.
- *Jules and Jim* (1962, Truffaut)
- *Optional: Band of Outsiders* (1964, Godard)

Week 16 · Dec 7–13

- *Contempt* (1963, Godard) — Godard with money, widescreen, and Brigitte Bardot; a film about the impossibility of the film it's inside.
- *Le Samourai* (1967, Melville) — where the influence loops back. Almost no dialogue; every frame is composition.
- *Optional: Pierrot le Fou* (1965, Godard)

Read: Truffaut, "A Certain Tendency of the French Cinema" (1954) — the manifesto, and short.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

(Holiday break: Dec 14 – Jan 3. Watch whatever you like, or nothing.)

Unit 6 · Japan

Weeks 17–20 · 4 – 31 Jan 2027

The deepest single national tradition on this list and the biggest single gap for most self-taught viewers. Ozu first, because his style is so rigorously constrained that once you notice the rules, every other director's choices become visible by contrast.

Week 17 · Jan 4–10 — Ozu

- *Late Spring* (1949, Ozu)
- *Tokyo Story* (1953, Ozu) — the camera sits three feet off the floor and almost never moves. Count how often he cuts to an empty room.
- *Optional: Early Summer* (1951, Ozu)

Week 18 · Jan 11–17 — Kurosawa, at length

- *Seven Samurai* (1954, Kurosawa) — 207 min. Take it as the week's whole assignment; split across two nights if you like.
- *Optional: Yojimbo* (1961, Kurosawa) — and note that Leone remade it as *A Fistful of Dollars*

Week 19 · Jan 18–24

- *Ugetsu* (1953, Mizoguchi) — long takes, ghost story, and camera movement as moral commentary.
- *Harakiri* (1962, Kobayashi) — the samurai film turned into an indictment of the samurai code. Formally immaculate.
- *Optional: Sansho the Bailiff* (1954, Mizoguchi)

Week 20 · Jan 25–31

- *High and Low* (1963, Kurosawa) — a kidnapping procedural that splits cleanly into two formal halves. The first hour is nearly a filmed play.
- *Woman in the Dunes* (1964, Teshigahara) — sand, in extreme close-up, for two and a half hours, and it works.
- *Optional: Tokyo Drifter* (1966, Suzuki)

Read: Bordwell on Ozu (his blog has years of it); Criterion's *Tokyo Story* essay.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 7 · The Northern Interior

Weeks 21–23 · 1 – 21 Feb 2027

The demanding stretch, placed here on purpose — by February you'll have the patience and the vocabulary for it. Bergman, Dreyer, Tarkovsky: films that are about faces, silence, doubt, and duration. Long, slow, and among the highest-value viewing on the list. If any unit is worth the extension film, it's this one.

Week 21 · Feb 1–7

- *Wild Strawberries* (1957, Bergman) — the warmest entry point.
- *The Seventh Seal* (1957, Bergman) — much funnier than its reputation.
- *Optional: Winter Light* (1963, Bergman)

Week 22 · Feb 8–14

- *Persona* (1966, Bergman) — the film breaks, literally, in the middle. Two faces merge. Nobody has satisfactorily explained it and that's fine.
- *Ordet* (1955, Dreyer) — 126 min. The final scene is one of the few in cinema that genuinely cannot be described.
- *Optional: Cries and Whispers* (1972, Bergman)

Week 23 · Feb 15–21

- *Stalker* (1979, Tarkovsky) — 161 min. Three men walk very slowly toward a room. It is either the most boring thing you've seen or it isn't.
- *Solaris* (1972, Tarkovsky) — 167 min. A long week; drop to one film if you need to and take

Stalker.

- *Optional: Andrei Rublev* (1966, Tarkovsky) — 205 min in the standard cut

Read: Tarkovsky, *Sculpting in Time* (excerpts); Criterion essay on *Ordet*.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 8 · New Hollywood

Weeks 24–27 · 22 Feb – 21 Mar 2027

Reward for Unit 7, and not a lesser unit for it. American directors who had absorbed exactly the European films you just watched, handed studio money, briefly, before the blockbuster closed the window. You'll now recognize the borrowings — the Antonioni in the drift, the Bertolucci in the light.

Week 24 · Feb 22–28

- *Bonnie and Clyde* (1967, Penn) — French New Wave technique smuggled into a studio picture. Truffaut and Godard were both approached to direct it.
- *The Graduate* (1967, Nichols)
- *Optional: The Wild Bunch* (1969, Peckinpah)

Week 25 · Mar 1–7

- *The Godfather* (1972, Coppola) — 175 min. Watch Gordon Willis's lighting, having just seen *The Conformist*.
- *Chinatown* (1974, Polanski) — noir rebuilt with everything Unit 2 taught you.
- *Optional: The Godfather Part II* (1974, Coppola) — 202 min

Week 26 · Mar 8–14

- *Nashville* (1975, Altman) — 160 min. Twenty-four characters, overlapping sound, no center. The anti-*Godfather*.
- *Taxi Driver* (1976, Scorsese)
- *Optional: McCabe & Mrs. Miller* (1971, Altman)

Week 27 · Mar 15–21

- *Days of Heaven* (1978, Malick) — shot almost entirely at magic hour. Nestor Almendros, twenty minutes of usable light a day.
- *Apocalypse Now* (1979, Coppola) — 147 min (theatrical cut). The window closing.
- *Optional: The Conversation* (1974, Coppola)

Read: Pauline Kael on *Nashville*; then Peter Biskind, *Easy Riders, Raging Bulls* (gossipy, fast, and genuinely useful context).

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 9 · Hong Kong and Taiwan

Weeks 28–30 · 22 Mar – 11 Apr 2027

The single most rewarding blind spot on your list. Wong Kar-wai and Edward Yang were making, in the 1990s, some of the best films anyone was making anywhere, and they're barely taught outside film departments.

Week 28 · Mar 22–28 — Wong Kar-wai

- *Days of Being Wild* (1990, Wong)
- *In the Mood for Love* (2000, Wong) — the film most often named the best of this century. Repetition, blocked sightlines, and a story told almost entirely in what's withheld.
- *Optional: Happy Together* (1997, Wong)

Week 29 · Mar 29 – Apr 4

- *Yi Yi* (2000, Yang) — 173 min. A family across three generations; possibly the most humane film on this syllabus.
- *Hard Boiled* (1992, Woo) — the counterweight, and a reminder that this industry also produced the most kinetic action filmmaking on earth.
- *Optional: A City of Sadness* (1989, Hou Hsiao-hsien)

Week 30 · Apr 5–11

- *A Brighter Summer Day* (1991, Yang) — 237 min. The week's single assignment. Two nights, and worth every minute.
- *Optional: Chungking Express* rewatch — you'll see a completely different film than you did in Week 2

Read: Criterion essays on *In the Mood for Love* and *A Brighter Summer Day*; Bordwell's *Planet Hong Kong* (excerpts).

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 10 · Off the Usual Axis

Weeks 31–33 · 12 Apr – 2 May 2027

India, Iran, Senegal. Traditions that developed largely outside the Hollywood/Europe conversation, and the correction to a canon that mostly wasn't looking.

Week 31 · Apr 12–18 — Satyajit Ray

- *Pather Panchali* (1955, Ray) — 125 min. Shot on weekends over three years with a mostly amateur crew.
- *Charulata* (1964, Ray)
- *Optional: Aparajito* (1956, Ray)

Week 32 · Apr 19–25 — Iran

- *Close-Up* (1990, Kiarostami) — 98 min. A man impersonates a film director; Kiarostami films the trial and then restages it with the real people. The documentary/fiction boundary simply dissolves. You will have opinions about the epistemology.
- *Taste of Cherry* (1997, Kiarostami)
- *Optional: Where Is the Friend's House?* (1987, Kiarostami)

Week 33 · Apr 26 – May 2 — Senegal

- *Black Girl* (1966, Sembène) — 60 min. Widely considered the first sub-Saharan African feature to reach international audiences.
- *Touki Bouki* (1973, Mambéty) — 88 min. Formally wilder than almost anything in Unit 5.
- *Optional: Xala* (1975, Sembène)

Read: Criterion's essay on *Close-Up*; the *Black Girl* liner notes.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 11 · Germany and the Political Film**Weeks 34–36 · 3 – 23 May 2027**

Films that treat history as an unresolved argument. The New German Cinema directors were working directly against a national silence, and the political thrillers here were made close enough to their events to be dangerous.

Week 34 · May 3–9

- *Aguirre, the Wrath of God* (1972, Herzog) — 95 min, shot on a stolen camera in the Peruvian jungle. The production stories are true.
- *Ali: Fear Eats the Soul* (1974, Fassbinder) — a remake of Sirk's *All That Heaven Allows*, transposed to Munich and race.
- *Optional: All That Heaven Allows* (1955, Sirk) — watch it *first* if you can

Week 35 · May 10–16

- *The Battle of Algiers* (1966, Pontecorvo) — 121 min. Shot documentary-style; the opening title card insists no newsreel footage was used, because viewers assumed otherwise.

- *Z* (1969, Costa-Gavras)
- *Optional: The Marriage of Maria Braun* (1979, Fassbinder)

Week 36 · May 17–23

- *Wings of Desire* (1987, Wenders) — Berlin from above, in monochrome, just before the wall came down.
- *Night and Fog* (1956, Resnais) — **32 min.** The most-taught documentary in film curricula, and the one that established how the form handles atrocity: present-tense color tracking shots over the empty camps, cut against black-and-white archive. Watch it before *Come and See*, not after.
- *Come and See* (1985, Klimov) — the hardest film on this syllabus by a wide margin, and unarguably a great one. Skip it if you'd rather; substitute *The Lives of Others* (2006, von Donnersmarck).
- *Optional: Shoah* (1985, Lanzmann) — 566 min; a long-term project rather than a week's viewing

This is the heaviest week of the year emotionally, not in runtime. Give it space, and don't stack it against a deadline.

Read: Criterion's *Battle of Algiers* materials, including the notorious 2003 Pentagon screening.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 12 · Cinema Now

Weeks 37–39 · 24 May – 13 Jun 2027

Post-1990, the canon still forming. You'll now be able to see these as arguments with everything above rather than as standalone entertainments — which is the whole return on the previous nine months.

Week 37 · May 24–30

- *A Separation* (2011, Farhadi) — the best-constructed screenplay of its decade; no character is wrong.
- *4 Months, 3 Weeks and 2 Days* (2007, Mungiu) — the Romanian New Wave long take at its most unbearable and most controlled.
- *Optional: The Lives of Others* (2006, von Donnersmarck)

Week 38 · May 31 – Jun 6

- *Memories of Murder* (2003, Bong)
- *Parasite* (2019, Bong) — watch them together and the sixteen-year throughline is obvious: the same director, the same class rage, vastly more control.
- *Optional: Burning* (2018, Lee Chang-dong)

Week 39 · Jun 7–13

- *Spirited Away* (2001, Miyazaki)
- *Portrait of a Lady on Fire* (2019, Sciamma) — a film about looking, made by someone who has clearly seen everything in Unit 4.
- *Optional: Beau Travail* (1999, Denis)

Read: Sight & Sound's 2022 Greatest Films poll and the essays around it — useful now that you can argue with it.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

Unit 13 · Capstone — Cinema as Pure Form

Weeks 40–42 · 14 Jun – 4 Jul 2027

Three weeks of films that are difficult only without context. You now have the context. This unit would have been miserable in September and should be exhilarating in June — which is itself the demonstration that the whole approach worked.

Week 40 · Jun 14–20

- *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968, Kubrick) — 149 min.
- *Playtime* (1967, Tati) — 124 min, shot in 70mm on a purpose-built city that bankrupted him. Two films from the same two years about human beings dwarfed by their own architecture.
- *La Jetée* (1962, Marker) — **28 min.** Told almost entirely in still photographs: a film about time and memory that questions whether cinema needs motion at all. Sitting beside Kubrick's vision of the future, it's the better companion piece of the two.
- *Optional: Solaris* rewatch, or *Stalker* if you skipped it

Week 41 · Jun 21–27

- *Mulholland Drive* (2001, Lynch)
- *Persona* rewatch — the Bergman film Lynch is unmistakably working from. Forty minutes in, the connection is not subtle.
- *Optional: Beau Travail* (1999, Denis)

Week 42 · Jun 28 – Jul 4

- *Jeanne Dielman, 23 quai du Commerce, 1080 Bruxelles* (1975, Akerman) — 201 min. A woman does housework in real time for three hours. Voted the greatest film ever made in the 2022 Sight & Sound poll, to widespread outrage. The week's single assignment, and the right film to end on: it will either vindicate the whole year or give you something to be productively furious about.
- *Optional: rewatch Citizen Kane* from Week 1. It's a good way to measure the distance.

After each film: [essay links for this unit](#) in the Reading Companion.

The numbers

Weeks	42 (plus a 3-week holiday break)
Core films	85
With extensions	~127 (a few are rewatches)
Pace	2–3 films/week
Longest single week	<i>A Brighter Summer Day</i> , 237 min
Shortest core film	<i>Meshes of the Afternoon</i> , 14 min
Weeks with 3+ core films	4 (weeks 9, 10, 36, 40) — extras are all shorts

Slack built in

Three weeks are single-film weeks by design (18, 30, 42). The holiday break is three weeks of nothing. Extensions are always optional. If you finish early, the extension list alone is another 40 films.

The four weeks carrying an extra title (9, 10, 36, 40) add 104 minutes between them across the whole year — roughly one additional feature, spread over ten months. They exist to close two gaps that every academic film course treats as essential and this plan originally skipped entirely: **German Expressionism**, and **non-narrative film** (avant-garde and documentary). Four short films is a cheap price for both.